

Executive Function Field Manual

Practical intervention reference for daily execution

Executive Dysfunction Pattern Map

Common patterns include startup paralysis, sequence loss, context-switch collapse, and completion drift. These are regulation and orchestration failures, not evidence of low effort.

Intervention begins by reducing decision load. Replace vague goals with physical first actions and make starts observable and time-bound.

Visible external systems are required: one task board, one calendar, one recovery checklist. Tool sprawl creates hidden cognitive tax.

Task Initiation Protocol

Use a strict startup script: define done in one sentence, gather materials for step one only, set ten-minute timer, start without renegotiating scope.

If no start after two attempts, add body doubling before trying harder solo. Escalate support early, not after burnout.

Track starts completed instead of only final completions. Start consistency is the leading indicator for long-term execution reliability.

Time Blindness Countermeasures

Always estimate then buffer. Include setup, transition, and shutdown time explicitly. Most planning errors come from missing hidden segments.

Use visual timers and checkpoint alarms. Time cues must be external and redundant.

Calibrate weekly: compare estimated vs actual durations and adjust default multipliers by task type.

Routine Engineering

Every routine needs three tiers: minimum, normal, and bad-day. Without fallback tiers, consistency collapses under stress.

Attach routines to stable anchors (after coffee, after shower, before laptop close). Cue-based sequencing outperforms motivation-based plans.

Weekly routine review should remove failing steps before adding new ones.

Repair After Misses

Misses are expected in ADHD support systems. Reliability comes from rapid repair, not perfect prevention.

Repair script: acknowledge impact, state immediate corrective action with timestamp, state one prevention change.

Use this script across school, work, and relationships to preserve trust while improving systems.

Sustainability Guardrails

Do not run panic mode as default productivity. Emergency cadence should be temporary and explicitly bounded.
Protect sleep, nutrition, and recovery blocks as execution infrastructure rather than optional wellness extras.
When overload persists, reduce commitments before adding optimization complexity.

OpenADHD educational resource. Not medical advice.